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Additional notes on harvesting of honeycombs plus honey and beeswax processing (2025)

Harvesting of honey combs means collecting of combs from the hive. Generally in Zambia harvesting of honeycombs takes place between October and November for *Brachystegia* dominated forests and between May and June for *Julbernadia* dominated woodlands. Generally, harvesting should be done early in the morning or in the late afternoon when it is cool and the bees are confined to their hives. The beekeeper should have the following requirements when going for harvesting; plastic containers in which to put the honey combs, I hive tool, a brush for removing the bees from the combs, protective clothing and a smoker to help provide the smoke. You should have at least one helper for easier harvesting.

Process;

Prepare the smoke in the smoker. Blow a moderate amount of smoke through the entrance of the hive. The smoke will drive the bees to one side of the hive. Remove the hive covering and start harvesting by removing top bar by to bar while continuing to blow in small puffs of smoke. Continue harvesting until you reach the brood area in the a Kenyan top bar hive. For langsloth hives, only harvest the supers. Leave enough honey for the bees themselves to feed on; otherwise they may abscond to a new home if you harvest all the honey. Once you have finished harvesting remember to replace the hive covering back on the hive.

Processing of honey;

Honey processing involves the extraction of honey from the combs. Honey processing should always start with grading. During processing, all impurities such as pollen, dead bees and other debris should be removed so that you end up with only clean sealed honey combs. After grading, honey can be extracted using different methods.

1. **Centrifugal honey extraction**: This is the best of all methods of extracting high quality honey from the honeycombs. The centrifugal honey extractor could be manual or electric operated.
2. **Honey press machine**: The use of a honey press machine is relatively cheaper and simple compared to the centrifugal honey extractor. The process involves- First break up or crush the combs with a cooking stick and put the pieces into a plastic container or buckets, put the crushed combs into a honey press with a clean cloth or mesh wire inside, apply pressure on the combs to extract the liquid honey and finally collect the honey for bottling.

3. Traditional method

- Light a fire. Put a big pot or half drum with water on the fire
- Put combs in a plastic container and crushed them. Close the container with a tight lid
- Place the plastic in the big pot or half drum with water on the fire. Make sure the plastic container honeycombs does note touch the big pot or half drum. Place a stand or some bricks to support the container inside the big pot or half drum
- This method indirectly heats the honey by heating the water in the pot of half drum which in turn heats up the plastic container with crushed honey combs. Ensure that the crushed honey combs melt into molten liquid.
- Pass the molten liquid through the calico cloth to remove the debris
- Leave the clean molten liquid to cool. Wax will form on top. Simply scoop off the wax with a big spoon until you remain with the honey
- You then have processed the honey ready for bottling once all the wax is removed.

Processing of beeswax;

After extracting or processing honey, the empty honeycombs or the crude wax can be further processed into beeswax, another valuable bee product. The following are the basic equipment and materials required; two pots to heat the combs, two straining containers, two pieces of sacks for straining, a piece of rope for squeezing out the wax and a piece of soap or detergent.

Procedure;

- Put the combs and or crude wax into a container.
- Foll the container with an amount of water equivalent to the amount of combs
- Heat the mixture to just below boiling point and stir continuously until the mixture is like soup.
- When all the wax is melted, pour it into the straining material held over a container by two helpers
- The third person should tie a rope around the lump of beeswax and then twist and squeeze out the molten wax.
- Leave the mixture of water and molten wax to cool and a solid layer of wax will float to the top of the water and solidify.
- Break the cake of wax into a clean container and add a few drops of water. Repeat the heating process until you get a clean cake of beeswax.